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The CSIR UGC NET December 2026 Countdown Playbook

The complete, verified system for the Joint CSIR-UGC NET on 19, 22 and 27 December 2026 — the five subjects decoded, the new Life Sciences & Biotechnology paper explained, the exact dates and fees, the marks and negative-marking maths, the real June 2026 cut-offs, and a 60-day plan from application to exam day.

5	19, 22 & 27	Rs.37,000
SUBJECTS	DECEMBER 2026	JRF PER MONTH

Every date, fee and rule in this playbook is taken from the National Testing Agency public notice dated 7 October 2026 and the official Joint CSIR-UGC NET December 2026 Information Bulletin. Verified October 2026.

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Twenty-five numbered sections in four parts. Read Part 1 first if you have not applied yet; read Parts 3 and 4 in the order you will need them.

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How to use this playbook

This playbook is built around one question: what do you have to do, between today and 19 December 2026, to walk into the exam hall knowing the paper, the maths and your own strategy cold?

It is arranged in the order you will actually need it. Sections 1 to 4 cover the exam itself and the application that is open right now. Sections 5 to 10 decode the paper, the marks, the cut-offs and what the fellowship is worth. Sections 11 to 14 are the working part — the 60-day plan, the section strategies, the mock system and exam-day execution. Sections 15 to 25 cover the traps, life after the exam, the FAQ, a practice set, the Part A topic map, a late-start plan, a glossary and a quick-reference card you can screenshot.

Three ground rules before you start:

- **Deadlines first.** The application window closes on 5 November 2026. If you have not applied, read Section 2 and Section 4 today, before anything else.
- **Know your paper, not just your subject.** CSIR NET rewards candidates who understand the attempt limits and the negative-marking maths. Section 5 and Section 12 are worth more than an extra week of reading.
- **Practise to the clock.** The paper is 180 minutes for 200 marks across three parts. Section 13 turns that into a weekly routine.

> **The one-line summary**
>
> CSIR NET is a single 200-mark, 3-hour computer-based test in one of five science subjects. It decides three things at once: a paid Junior Research Fellowship, eligibility to teach as Assistant Professor, and admission to a PhD. The December 2026 cycle is the first to merge Life Sciences with Biotechnology into one paper, and applications are open from 7 October to 5 November 2026.

A note on honesty: this is an independent study guide, not a publication of NTA, CSIR or the Government of India. Exam dates, fees and rules are quoted from official sources and dated, but official notices can change. Always confirm the final details on csirnet.nta.nic.in and csirhrdg.res.in before you act.

1. The exam on one page

The Joint CSIR-UGC National Eligibility Test is a single computer-based test conducted twice a year, in June and December, by the National Testing Agency on behalf of the Council of Scientific and Industrial Research. It is the gateway exam for science postgraduates who want to do funded research or teach in an Indian university or college.

One exam, three possible outcomes. The result committee places every successful candidate into one of three categories. Where you land decides what you can do next.

Category	What you are eligible for	JRF money?	Teaching?
Category 1	Award of Junior Research Fellowship and appointment as Assistant Professor (and PhD admission)	Yes	Yes
Category 2	Appointment as Assistant Professor and admission to PhD	No	Yes
Category 3	Admission to PhD only	No	No

A candidate who qualifies for JRF is automatically eligible to teach as Assistant Professor, subject to UGC's minimum eligibility conditions. It does not work the other way round: qualifying only for Assistant Professor or for PhD admission does not bring the fellowship.

What the fellowship is worth

A JRF selected through CSIR NET receives Rs.37,000 per month for the first two years, plus an annual contingent grant of Rs.20,000, plus house rent allowance where hostel accommodation is not available. On completing two years as a JRF and registering for a PhD, the fellowship upgrades to Senior Research Fellow at Rs.42,000 per month for the third and later years, subject to a progress assessment. The tenure runs up to five years or the completion of the PhD.

Why the December 2026 cycle is different

Two things make this cycle unlike any before it. First, the CSIR NET Life Sciences paper and the Department of Biotechnology's Biotechnology Eligibility Test have been merged into one paper, Life Sciences and Biotechnology, from this cycle onward. Second, the application window is open now and closes on 5 November 2026. Section 7 covers the merger in detail; Section 2 gives you the deadline list.

> **Who should read this**
>
> Final-year and completed Master's students in the physical, chemical, life, mathematical and earth sciences; four-year bachelor's degree holders in science and engineering; and anyone already working who wants a funded PhD or a teaching career. There is no upper age limit for the Assistant Professor or PhD routes.

2. Every date that matters

These dates are taken from the NTA public notice dated 7 October 2026 and the official December 2026 Information Bulletin. NTA lists the exam dates as tentative, so treat the last column as the place to re-check.

Activity	Date / window	Notes
Application window opens	7 October 2026	Online only, at csirnet.nta.nic.in
Application + fee closes	5 November 2026, 11:50 PM	Hard deadline — no extension promised
Late-fee application window	6 – 9 November 2026	Rs.500 late fee, subject to a successful transaction by 9 Nov
Correction window	10 – 12 November 2026	Online only; limited fields
City intimation slip	To be announced	Released a few days before the admit card
Admit card download	To be announced	Download from csirnet.nta.nic.in only
Exam days	19, 22 and 27 December 2026	Your subject's exact date is on the admit card
Shift timings	9:00 AM – 12:00 noon / 3:00 PM – 6:00 PM	180 minutes each, no break
Answer key challenge	Announced after the exam	Rs.200 per challenged question
Result	To be announced	Scorecard carries marks and percentile

What to do this week

If you are reading this around publication, you have roughly two weeks before the application closes. Do these five things in order, and do not start serious study until the first one is done.

1. **Check your eligibility now** — your Master's percentage, your subject code, and your age against the JRF limit (Section 3).
2. **Complete or refresh your registration** on the NTA portal and keep your application number safe.
3. **Choose your subject code carefully.** Once submitted, the subject is not freely changeable, and your Part B and Part C paper is fixed by it.
4. **Pay the fee before 5 November.** An application without a successful fee transaction is not a valid application.
5. **Only then** open Section 11 and start the 60-day plan.

> **The date to circle in red**
>
> 5 November 2026 is the only date on this page you cannot recover from. Miss it and the late window costs you an extra Rs.500 and a tighter margin; miss that and the cycle is gone until June 2027.

3. Eligibility, decoded line by line

Eligibility for CSIR NET has two parts: your qualification (marks and degree) and your age. Get the first wrong and your form is rejected later, even after you sit the exam. Read this section against your own marksheet.

Qualification: the marks you need

Your degree	General / EWS	OBC-NCL / SC / ST / PwD / PwBD / Third gender
Master's degree or equivalent (M.Sc. and similar)	At least 55%	At least 50%
Integrated BS-MS, four-year BS, B.E., B.Tech, B.Pharma, MBBS	At least 75% (UGC PhD norms; 5% relaxation for reserved categories)	At least 70%
Final-year / result-awaited candidates	May apply provisionally	May apply provisionally

The percentages are taken without rounding off, so 54.9% is not 55%. If your result is awaited, you can apply and sit the exam, but your selection is provisional. Candidates who qualify for JRF or for Assistant Professor must complete the degree with the required marks within two years of the result; those qualifying for PhD admission only must do so within one year.

Age: the rule most people misread

For the Junior Research Fellowship, you must be not more than 30 years old as on the first day of the month in which the exam concludes. Because the exam concludes in December 2026, that cut-off date is 1 December 2026. For Assistant Professor and for PhD admission there is no upper age limit at all.

Category	JRF age relaxation	Assistant Professor / PhD
General / EWS	None (limit 30 years)	No upper age limit
OBC-NCL, SC, ST, PwD / PwBD, Third gender	Up to 5 years	No upper age limit
Women applicants	Up to 5 years	No upper age limit
Candidates with research experience in the relevant subject	Up to 5 years, on production of a certificate	No upper age limit
Ex-servicemen	Up to 5 years, limited to length of service	No upper age limit

Two cautions. Total age relaxation from all grounds combined cannot exceed five years under any circumstances. And research experience counts only if it was in the relevant or related subject of your post-graduation and was not part of your own degree work — you will need a certificate from a recognised university, institute or public-sector employer.

> **Eligibility check in 30 seconds**
>
> 1) Do I hold (or am I about to hold) a Master's with 55% / 50%, or a four-year science or engineering degree with 75% / 70%? 2) Am I 30 or under on 1 December 2026, or do I qualify for relaxation? 3) Do I want JRF, teaching, or PhD — because the third answer has no age limit. If all three clear, apply.

4. The fee, and how to apply without losing a year

The application is entirely online at csirnet.nta.nic.in. There is no offline route and no paper form. The fee is non-refundable, so check your eligibility before you pay.

Category	Application fee
General / Unreserved	Rs.1,150
General-EWS / OBC-NCL	Rs.600
SC / ST / PwD / PwBD / Third gender	Rs.325
Late-fee surcharge (6 – 9 Nov 2026)	Rs.500, in addition to the fee

Fees are paid online through credit card, debit card, net banking or UPI. The exact figure is shown on the payment page at the moment you pay; confirm it there as the final word.

The application, step by step

1. Open csirnet.nta.nic.in and register with your own mobile number and email — NTA sends every update to these, so never use a friend's.
2. Log in and fill the online application form. Enter your name, date of birth, category and qualification exactly as they appear on your certificates.
3. Select your subject code (701 to 705). This decides your Parts B and C paper.
4. Select up to four exam-city preferences from the list shown for your state.
5. Upload a recent passport photograph and your signature in the sizes and formats the portal specifies.
6. Choose the medium of the paper — Hindi or English. If the two versions ever differ, the English version is treated as final.
7. Review the preview screen line by line before you submit. This is your last clean look.
8. Pay the fee and wait for the confirmation. Save the payment reference and download the confirmation page.
9. If you spot a mistake, use the correction window of 10 – 12 November 2026 for the fields it allows.
10. Keep your application number, login and confirmation page safe until the result is out.

The eight application mistakes that cost people a cycle

- Paying the fee but never completing the final submission step.
- Name or date-of-birth mismatch against the matriculation certificate.
- Uploading a blurred, old or oversized photograph or signature.
- Choosing the wrong subject code, then discovering it is locked.
- Using a mobile number or email you cannot access.
- Leaving the form open until the last hour and hitting a slow portal.
- Assuming the late-fee window is a safety net — it costs Rs.500 and closes on 9 November.
- Not downloading the confirmation page, then having no proof of payment.

5. The paper decoded: three parts, one clock

Every CSIR NET paper is a single 200-mark test of 180 minutes with no break, in three parts. Part A is common to all five subjects and tests general aptitude. Parts B and C are subject-specific, and their structure differs by subject — which is exactly why two candidates in different subjects face a different paper and a different strategy.

What each part is testing

- **Part A (30 marks, common to all):** general aptitude — logical reasoning, graphical analysis, analytical and numerical ability, quantitative comparison, series formation and puzzles. You answer 15 of 20 questions at 2 marks each.
- **Part B (70 or 75 marks, subject-specific):** conventional multiple-choice questions covering your syllabus. The number of questions and the marks per question vary by subject.
- **Part C (95 or 100 marks, subject-specific):** higher-order, analytical questions that test how you apply concepts to a problem, not just recall. This is where the paper is won or lost.

The pattern, subject by subject

Read your own subject's row carefully. The attempt limits are not advice — they are enforced. If you answer more questions than the limit in a part, only the first ones up to the limit are evaluated, in the order you answered them.

Chemical Sciences (701)

Part	Total questions	Answer at most	Marks per correct	Deducted per wrong
A	20	15	2	0.5
B	40	35	2	0.5
C	60	25	4	1
Total	120	75	200 marks	25% negative in A, B and C

Earth, Atmospheric, Ocean and Planetary Sciences (702)

Part	Total questions	Answer at most	Marks per correct	Deducted per wrong
A	20	15	2	0.5
B	50	35	2	0.5
C	80	25	4	1.32 (33% negative)
Total	150	75	200 marks	Part C is stricter than any other subject

Life Sciences and Biotechnology (703) — the new merged paper

Part	Total questions	Answer at most	Marks per correct	Deducted per wrong
A	20	15	2	0.5
B	50	35	2	0.5
C	75	25	4	1
Total	145	75	200 marks	25% negative in A, B and C

Mathematical Sciences (704)

Part	Total questions	Answer at most	Marks per correct	Deducted per wrong
A	20	15	2	0.5
B	40	25	3	0.75
C	60	20	4.75	None — but all-or-nothing
Total	120	60	200 marks	Part C has no negative marking

Physical Sciences (705)

Part	Total questions	Answer at most	Marks per correct	Deducted per wrong
A	20	15	2	0.5
B	25	20	3.5	0.875
C	30	20	5	1.25
Total	75	55	200 marks	25% negative in A, B and C

The rule that catches people out

In every subject, the paper prints more questions than you are allowed to answer. The attempt limits above are hard ceilings. Answer 26 questions in a Part C that allows 25, and the 26th is simply ignored — but if you answered it early and skipped an easier one later, you have lost marks for nothing. Decide your count before you start, not as you go.

One more thing unique to Mathematics

In the Mathematical Sciences paper, Part C questions can have one or more correct options. You earn credit only if you mark all the correct options and none of the wrong ones. There is no partial credit and no negative marking in that part. That combination makes Part C a precision game: a near-miss scores exactly the same as a blank, so attempt only what you can reason to a clean answer.

6. The five subjects and what each one covers

Your subject code fixes your Parts B and C. The table below shows the specialisations each subject spans, so you can confirm you are entering the right paper.

Code	Subject	Specialisations covered
701	Chemical Sciences	Analytical, Inorganic, Organic and Physical Chemistry, and others
702	Earth, Atmospheric, Ocean and Planetary Sciences	Geology, Geophysics, Meteorology, Oceanography, Physical Geography, and others
703	Life Sciences and Biotechnology	Biochemistry, Biodiversity and Taxonomy, Biotechnology, Botany, Genetics, Microbiology, Physiology, Zoology, and others
704	Mathematical Sciences	Applied Mathematics, Pure Mathematics, Statistics, and others
705	Physical Sciences	Atomic and Molecular Physics, Classical Dynamics, Condensed Matter, Electromagnetics, Experimental Design, Electronics, Nuclear and Particle Physics, Quantum Physics, Thermodynamics, and others

The paper is bilingual, in Hindi and English. You choose your medium in the application form, and if the two versions ever disagree, the English version is treated as final.

Choosing well

If your Master's is in a subject that sits between two codes — say, biophysics or geochemistry — read the syllabus on csirhrdg.res.in before you commit. The subject code you submit is the paper you will sit, and changing it later is not a routine request.

7. The December 2026 change: Life Sciences and Biotechnology merge

The single biggest change in this cycle is the merger of the CSIR NET Life Sciences paper with the Department of Biotechnology's Biotechnology Eligibility Test. From December 2026, both become one paper: Life Sciences and Biotechnology, subject code 703.

Why it happened, and what it means for you

CSIR and DBT merged the two exams to remove duplication and reflect how interdisciplinary biological research has become. Candidates raised three concerns during consultation, and CSIR answered each one in writing on 13 January 2026:

- **Concern: fewer fellowships.** CSIR clarified there is no impact on the number of fellowships on account of the merger. CSIR and DBT continue to provide fellowships as before; only the selection is through one common exam.
- **Concern: harder paper for traditional Life Sciences students.** The merged paper is designed to carry adequate optional questions from both traditional Life Sciences and Biotechnology, so candidates from either background can attempt enough questions from their own area.
- **Concern: more competition for Biotechnology students.** Evaluation is built around conceptual understanding, analytical ability and research aptitude in broader concepts rather than narrow, specialised knowledge.

One genuine gain for Biotechnology candidates: qualified candidates from a Biotechnology background are now eligible for all three result categories — JRF with Assistant Professor,

Assistant Professor with PhD admission, and PhD admission only. Under the old DBT-BET, that was not the case.

The revised syllabus at a glance

The merged syllabus keeps the core units and adds three new biotechnology-focused ones. Candidates from a traditional Life Sciences background should give the new units deliberate attention; candidates from Biotechnology should make sure the core units are solid. The units are:

Core units	New or restructured units
1. Structure and Function of Biomolecules 2. Cellular Organization 3. Fundamental Processes 4. Cell Communication and Cell Signaling 5. Developmental Biology 6. System Physiology — Plant 7. System Physiology — Animal 8. Inheritance Biology 9. Evolution and Diversity of Life Forms 10. Ecology and Behavioural Biology	11. Bioinformatics and Computational Biology (new) 12. Biochemical Engineering and Industrial Biotechnology (new) 13. Advances in Biotechnology (new — recombinant DNA, CRISPR, synthetic biology, stem cells, nanobiotechnology, metabolic engineering, GMOs, IPR)

What to do about it

Get the revised syllabus from csirhrdg.res.in and tick off every unit against your own notes. The three new units are where most candidates will be weakest, so they are also where a little extra reading moves you up the merit list fastest.

8. Qualifying, merit, and how fellowships are allotted

Passing is not a fixed score. CSIR NET works on a merit list with a minimum benchmark, and then divides the successful candidates between two funding bodies. Understanding the machinery tells you what you are actually aiming at.

The minimum benchmark

- There is a minimum benchmark of **33%** for General, EWS and OBC candidates, and **25%** for SC, ST and PwD candidates, for both the fellowship and the Assistant Professor routes.
- There is **no separate cut-off for Part A, Part B or Part C.** Only the cumulative marks across all three parts are used to draw the merit list.
- Within each subject and category, cut-offs are set by the result committee. They move from cycle to cycle with the difficulty of the paper and the number of fellowships available.

How ranks and fellowships are allotted

Ranks are first allotted to everyone who qualifies for the Junior Research Fellowship, in merit order. Those candidates are then distributed between CSIR and UGC in the ratio of fellowships shared between the two bodies for each subject. The number of fellowships is limited per subject and can vary from cycle to cycle — which is why a score that qualified last time is a guide, not a guarantee.

Your scorecard

The scorecard is published with both your total marks and your percentile score. Because the same subject can be held across multiple shifts and question sets, the percentile is the fairer way to read your own performance against the field.

The honest target

Do not aim to just clear the 33% benchmark — that benchmark only stops your paper being thrown out. Aim for the previous cycle's JRF cut-off in your subject and category (Section 9). That is the number that actually buys the fellowship.

9. Real targets: the June 2026 cut-offs

This is the most useful data in the playbook. These are the actual minimum cut-off percentages from the June 2026 cycle, released by CSIR-HRDG after the exam held on 17 and 18 July 2026. Use your subject and category to find your real target.

Junior Research Fellowship — minimum cut-off percentage

Subject	UR	EWS	OBC	SC	ST	PwD
Chemical Science	62.250	56.250	55.000	43.500	38.500	27.750
Earth Science	71.020	64.700	65.380	55.540	57.610	33.650
Life Science	66.500	59.250	58.000	49.500	44.750	30.750
Mathematical Science	43.000	37.625	37.500	30.250	27.375	25.250
Physical Science	45.875	40.125	41.250	34.438	34.563	25.625

Assistant Professor — minimum cut-off percentage

Subject	UR	EWS	OBC	SC	ST	PwD
Chemical Science	56.025	50.625	49.500	39.150	34.650	25.000
Earth Science	63.918	58.230	58.842	49.986	51.849	30.285
Life Science	59.850	53.325	52.200	44.550	40.275	27.675
Mathematical Science	38.700	33.863	33.750	27.225	25.000	25.000
Physical Science	41.288	36.113	37.125	30.994	31.107	25.000

PhD admission only — minimum cut-off percentage

Subject	UR	EWS	OBC	SC	ST	PwD
Chemical Science	46.250	37.750	38.500	30.250	28.250	25.000
Earth Science	54.880	44.990	48.240	40.830	42.810	25.470
Life Science	50.250	40.500	42.000	36.500	33.000	25.000
Mathematical Science	33.000	33.000	33.000	25.000	25.500	25.000
Physical Science	34.938	33.000	33.000	25.000	25.000	25.000

How to read these numbers

The JRF cut-off is always the highest of the three, because it is the scarcest prize. Notice how wide the subject-to-subject gap is: a General-category Physical Sciences candidate needed about 45.9% for JRF in June 2026, while an Earth Sciences candidate needed about 71.0%. Your subject matters as much as your effort. Also notice how much lower the SC, ST and PwD cut-offs sit — if you belong to a reserved category, the benchmark is genuinely different, and you should target that column, not the UR one.

How many actually qualify

June 2026 result	Number of candidates
Qualified for JRF under the CSIR scheme	1,413
Qualified for JRF only (not eligible for Assistant Professor)	20
Qualified for JRF under the UGC scheme	1,856
Total JRF-qualified candidates	3,289

That is roughly 3,300 fellowships across five subjects and every category. The competition is real, but it is also finite and knowable. A candidate who targets the previous cycle's cut-off for their own subject and category is aiming at a number that a real person hit last time.

Turn the cut-off into a study number

Take your subject's UR (or your category's) JRF cut-off above, add 3 to 4 percentage points as a safety margin, and convert it into marks: your target marks = target percent x 2 (since the paper is out of 200). For example, a General Physical Sciences target of 45.875% plus margin becomes about 98 to 100 marks out of 200. That single number should sit at the top of your study desk.

10. What you are playing for: the fellowship maths

It helps to keep the prize in view. A CSIR NET JRF is not a one-off cash prize; it is a monthly income for up to five years while you do a PhD, and it comes with a career door attached.

What	Value
JRF stipend, first two years	Rs.37,000 per month
Annual contingent grant (research expenses)	Rs.20,000 per year, reimbursed to the fellow
House rent allowance	As per host-institution rules, where hostel accommodation is not available
Upgrade to Senior Research Fellow (SRF)	Rs.42,000 per month from year three, after a progress assessment
Tenure	Up to five years, or completion of the PhD
Validity of the JRF-NET certificate	Two years from the effective date — you must join within this window
Validity of the Assistant Professor certificate	No end period

The Assistant Professor route is separate money. If you qualify for teaching, an Assistant Professor appointment in a university or college sits at Academic Level 10 of the UGC pay scale, with a starting basic pay of Rs.57,700 that rises across the scale. The certificate that gets you there never expires.

What the fellowship unlocks beyond the money

- Registration for a PhD without a separate entrance test in many universities, since CSIR NET is accepted in place of institutional PhD entrance exams.
- Access to national laboratories, IITs and recognised research establishments as a funded research fellow.
- A track record that counts towards teaching and research posts later.
- The freedom to choose a supervisor and a project from a position of funding, rather than applying cap in hand.

> **The two-year clock**
>
> The JRF-NET certificate is valid for two years. That means the exam you sit in December 2026 gives you until roughly the end of 2028 to accept a fellowship and start. If you are finishing a degree or weighing options, that window is your friend — but it does close.

11. The 60-day plan: 22 October to 19 December

This plan assumes you have already applied, or will apply this week. It runs in three phases and works backward from the exam dates of 19, 22 and 27 December 2026. Adjust the start if your subject's exam falls on 22 or 27 December — you simply get a few more days in Phase 3.

Phase	Dates	What this phase is for	Weekly rhythm
Phase 1: Lock and build	22 Oct – 12 Nov	Finish the application and the correction window; rebuild your subject fundamentals unit by unit; start one Part A drill a day.	5 study days + 1 mock-analysis day + 1 rest day
Phase 2: Depth and mocks	13 Nov – 6 Dec	Move from reading to solving; one full-length mock every week; keep an error log; tighten Part C analytical practice.	3 mocks in the phase; 2 full revision passes per unit
Phase 3: Peak and taper	7 Dec – 18 Dec	Two full mocks in exam conditions, then a deliberate taper: revise your error log and formula or concept sheets only.	Mock, analyse, light revision, rest

Phase 1 in detail (22 October – 12 November)

- **Week 1:** apply or verify your application; download the syllabus for your code; list every unit and sub-topic in a spreadsheet with a blank 'confidence' column you will fill after each pass.
- **Week 2:** first pass over your three weakest units. One Part A aptitude set of 20 questions every single day, timed to 20 minutes.
- **Week 3:** first pass over your three strongest units, then start Part B practice question banks.

- **Week 4:** sit your first full-length mock at the end of the phase. Do not judge your score — judge your section timings.

Phase 2 in detail (13 November – 6 December)

- One full-length mock every week, always at the same shift time as your real exam.
- The day after each mock, spend as long analysing it as you spent sitting it — every wrong answer, every guess, every skipped question.
- Rebuild a one-page concept or formula sheet per unit as you revise. These sheets become your only revision material in Phase 3.
- Introduce Part C practice deliberately: 20 analytical questions per session, with full working, no shortcuts.

Phase 3 in detail (7 December – 18 December)

- Two full mocks in the first week, under exact exam conditions — same start time, same 180-minute clock, no breaks.
- Then taper. From about five days out, stop new material entirely.
- Revise only your one-page sheets and your error log.
- Sleep on a fixed schedule from the start of Phase 3. Exam-day alertness is built in the last week, not the night before.

Your eight-week calendar at a glance

Week	Dates	Milestone
1	22 – 28 Oct	Application done; syllabus mapped; daily Part A drill begins
2	29 Oct – 4 Nov	Weakest three units, first pass
3	5 – 11 Nov	Application closed; strongest three units, first pass
4	12 – 18 Nov	Mock 1 and full analysis; Part B question banks
5	19 – 25 Nov	Second pass on weak units; Part C practice begins
6	26 Nov – 2 Dec	Mock 2; error-log review; concept sheets built
7	3 – 9 Dec	Mock 3; attempt-limit and pacing locked
8	10 – 18 Dec	Mocks 4 and 5; then taper to error log and concept sheets

> **The 3:1 mock rule**
>
> For every hour you spend sitting a mock, spend three hours analysing it. A mock you sit and never review teaches you almost nothing; a mock you dissect rebuilds your strategy. This one rule separates candidates who plateau from candidates who climb.

12. Section strategies: how to play A, B and C

Your subject knowledge is assumed. What wins marks is how you spend 180 minutes across three parts with different marks, different risks and different attempt limits. This section is the strategy layer.

Part A: the cheapest 30 marks in the paper

Part A is common to every subject and tests general aptitude: logical reasoning, graphical analysis, analytical and numerical ability, quantitative comparison, series formation and puzzles. You answer 15 of 20 questions at 2 marks each. These marks are the most predictable in the paper, and many science candidates leave them to chance. Do not. Twenty minutes of daily practice turns Part A into a reliable 24 to 30 marks, and those marks are identical in value to the hardest Part C question.

Part B: build the base, protect the clock

Part B is conventional subject multiple-choice. It is where breadth pays. Answer the questions you know cleanly and fast, and do not sink time into one stubborn question when five easier ones are waiting. Because Part B carries 2 to 3.5 marks per question depending on your subject, it is also where volume matters most — clear as many as you honestly can within the attempt limit.

Part C: the part that decides your rank

Part C carries 4 to 5 marks per question — the highest value in the paper — and it tests application, not recall. It is where a well-prepared candidate separates from a well-read one. Treat every Part C question as a small problem to solve, not a fact to recognise. In Mathematics, remember the all-or-nothing rule: no partial credit, no negative marking, so attempt only what you can solve cleanly.

The maths of guessing: when a guess is worth it

With four options and negative marking, a random guess has a negative expected value in every part of the paper. But an educated guess — where you have eliminated two options — can be positive. The table below shows the expected marks from guessing one question at each level of confidence.

Situation (4 options, 1 correct)	Part A / B (2 marks, 0.5 penalty)	Part C (4 marks, 1 penalty)	Maths Part C (4.75 marks, no penalty)
Pure guess, no elimination	–0.125	–0.25	+1.19
One option eliminated (3 left)	+0.33	+0.67	+1.19
Two options eliminated (2 left)	+0.75	+1.50	+1.19
Three options eliminated (certain)	+2.00	+4.00	+4.75

Read the first row carefully: in Parts A and B, a blind guess loses you marks on average, and in Part C it loses you even more. The second row is the turning point — once you can eliminate even one option, guessing becomes worth it. In Mathematics Part C there is no penalty at all, so an informed attempt is always rational, but the all-or-nothing scoring means you should only commit to an option set you can defend.

Your attempt plan, subject by subject

Fix these numbers before exam day. Writing them down removes hesitation inside the hall.

Subject	Part A attempts	Part B attempts	Part C attempts	Total
Chemical Sciences	15	35	25	75
Earth Sciences	15	35	25	75
Life Sciences and Biotechnology	15	35	25	75
Mathematical Sciences	15	25	20	60
Physical Sciences	15	20	20	55

The clock plan for 180 minutes

Spend about 20 minutes on Part A, about 60 to 70 minutes on Part B, and reserve the remaining 90 to 100 minutes for Part C, which carries the most marks. Check the clock at the end of each part and adjust the next part's pace. Never let Part B run so long that Part C is rushed — that is the most common way strong candidates lose a rank.

13. The mock system that actually moves your score

A mock is not a test of how good you are. It is a rehearsal of how you will behave under a clock, and its real value is in the debrief. Run mocks the same way every time so that exam day feels like the hundredth time, not the first.

The weekly mock routine

1. **Sit it in one block.** 180 minutes, no pause, no phone, at the same shift time as your real exam.
2. **Attempt to your plan.** Use the attempt numbers from Section 12. If you deviate, note why.
3. **Mark it honestly.** Apply the negative marking for your subject exactly. Do not give yourself the benefit of the doubt.
4. **Log every miss.** For each wrong or skipped question, write one line: the concept, and whether the cause was knowledge, reading, or time.
5. **Rebuild the fix.** Turn each cause into a specific action — a page to re-read, a type of question to drill, a pacing change.

The error log is the whole game

Most candidates who improve fast are not studying more — they are studying their own mistakes. Keep a single running document with four columns: question topic, what went wrong, the correct idea in one line, and the date you fixed it. By the last week, this log and your one-page concept sheets are the only things you revise.

Mock	When (suggested)	Focus
Mock 1	End of Phase 1 (early November)	Baseline and section timings; expect a low score
Mock 2	Mid Phase 2 (late November)	Pacing and Part C accuracy
Mock 3	End of Phase 2 (early December)	Full strategy, attempt limits, negative-marking discipline
Mock 4	First week of Phase 3	Exam conditions, same shift time
Mock 5	About a week before your exam	Final rehearsal, then taper

Track two numbers across every mock: your section timings and your accuracy in Part C. If Part C accuracy is rising, you are genuinely getting better. If your overall score is rising but Part C accuracy is flat, you are only getting luckier on Part A and B — and luck does not travel to exam day.

14. Exam-day playbook

The exam is a computer-based test at a centre, in one of two shifts. The logistics are simple, but small failures here cost marks you have already earned. Plan the day the way you plan a study week.

The week before

- Download the advance city intimation slip when it is released, and confirm your centre's exact location, not just the city.
- Download the admit card as soon as it is available and check your name, subject, date, shift and centre.
- Print the admit card and carry a photo ID that matches it exactly.
- Do a dry run of the route to the centre if it is unfamiliar.
- Re-read the instructions page on the admit card — reporting time, prohibited items and the gate-closing rule are all stated there.

What to carry

Carry	Do not carry
Printed admit card (and one spare copy)	Any electronic device, including phones and smart watches
Original photo ID matching your application	Study material, notes or loose paper
A transparent water bottle if permitted	Any metal item beyond what the centre allows
Your own pen, if you prefer (the portal may provide one)	Watches with communication features

Report well before your shift. Centres typically require you to be seated and verified before the paper starts, and gates can close ahead of the shift time. Treat the reporting time on your admit card as the latest you may arrive, not the earliest.

The 180-minute clock, planned

Time	What you are doing
First 15 minutes	Read the paper structure; note the attempt limits; settle your nerves before you touch a question.
Minutes 15 – 35	Part A. Move briskly; these are the most predictable marks in the paper.
Minutes 35 – 105	Part B. Clear what you know cleanly; do not sink time into one stubborn question.
Minutes 105 – 170	Part C. Highest-value marks; work each question as a small problem.
Last 10 minutes	Review only what you flagged. Do not start a new long calculation you cannot finish.

Three exam-hall habits

- **Count before you commit.** Keep a mental tally of how many you have answered in each part, so you never cross an attempt limit.
- **Skip without guilt.** A question you leave blank costs nothing. A question you guess blindly costs marks. Blank is a legitimate answer.
- **Flag, do not stall.** If a question resists you for more than a minute or two, mark it and move on. Come back only if the clock allows.

15. The traps, in one list

Almost everyone who loses a cycle to CSIR NET loses it to one of these. Read the list once now, and once again before your exam.

Application traps

- Assuming the fee payment is the last step — the final submission is.
- A name or date-of-birth mismatch against official records.
- A photograph or signature that does not meet the portal's format rules.
- Selecting the wrong subject code and discovering it is effectively locked.
- Using an email or phone number you cannot access for updates.
- Waiting for the last day and losing the slot to a slow portal.

Paper traps

- Crossing an attempt limit — extra answers are simply ignored, often wasting the time you needed elsewhere.
- Blind guessing in Parts A and B, where the expected value is negative.
- In Mathematics Part C, marking a partial answer set — there is no partial credit, so a near-miss scores as a blank.
- In Earth Sciences Part C, forgetting that the penalty is 33%, not 25%.
- Spending so long on Part B that Part C, the highest-value part, is rushed.

- Ignoring Part A aptitude because 'it is not my subject' — it is 30 identical marks.

Post-exam traps

- Not challenging an obviously wrong answer key within the challenge window.
- Missing the answer-key challenge fee deadline (Rs.200 per question).
- Assuming a certificate is enough — the JRF certificate must be used within its two-year validity.

> **The single biggest trap**
>
> Crossing an attempt limit. It feels harmless — you answered an extra question, so surely more is better. It is not. The extra answer is discarded, and if you answered it early, you may have skipped an easier question you would have got right. Count your attempts as you go, in every part.

16. After the exam: keys, results and what comes next

The exam is not the last decision point. How you handle the weeks after it can still change your outcome.

The answer key challenge

NTA displays the recorded responses and a provisional answer key after the exam. If a question or an answer is clearly wrong, you can challenge it online for a non-refundable Rs.200 per question. Challenges are accepted only through the prescribed online link and only with justification — not by email, post or phone. If a question is found to be wrong, the benefit of marks goes to the candidates who attempted it. This is a real lever: a single corrected question in Part C is worth 4 marks, and 4 marks can move you across a cut-off.

The result and scorecard

The result is declared on the NTA website with a scorecard showing both your total marks and your percentile score. Percentile is the fairer comparison, because the same subject can be conducted across multiple shifts and question sets. Ranks are allotted first to JRF-qualified candidates, who are then distributed between CSIR and UGC by the subject-wise fellowship ratio.

What your outcome means

If you qualified for	Your next move
JRF + Assistant Professor	Approach supervisors and institutions now; the certificate is valid for two years, so plan your PhD start within that window.
Assistant Professor + PhD admission	You can teach and register for a PhD; the teaching certificate has no expiry.
PhD admission only	Use the score as your PhD entrance; it is valid for one year from the result for admission.
Not qualified this time	You can sit the June 2027 cycle. Keep your error log — it is your fastest route to a better score.

If you qualified for JRF, do not wait. Institutions allocate fellowships against available slots, and a funded candidate who moves early gets the better supervisor and the better project. The certificate is a key; the door still has to be opened.

17. Frequently asked questions

Is CSIR NET the same as UGC NET?

No. They are separate exams with separate subject lists. UGC NET covers 87 subjects across the humanities, social sciences, languages, commerce and computer applications, and is conducted for the University Grants Commission. CSIR NET covers five science subjects and is conducted for the Council of Scientific and Industrial Research. Both can lead to a Junior Research Fellowship and Assistant Professor eligibility, but in different fields.

What are the exact exam dates for December 2026?

The NTA public notice dated 7 October 2026 lists 19, 22 and 27 December 2026, in two shifts (9:00 AM to 12:00 noon and 3:00 PM to 6:00 PM). NTA marks exam dates as tentative, and your exact date and shift are on your admit card.

When is the last date to apply?

5 November 2026, up to 11:50 PM, including the fee payment. A late-fee window runs from 6 to 9 November 2026 with an extra Rs.500, and corrections are allowed from 10 to 12 November 2026.

What is the application fee?

Rs.1,150 for General or Unreserved candidates, Rs.600 for General-EWS or OBC-NCL, and Rs.325 for SC, ST, PwD, PwBD and Third gender candidates. The exact figure is shown on the payment page; the fee is non-refundable.

How many marks do I need to pass?

There is no fixed pass mark. There is a minimum benchmark of 33% for General, EWS and OBC, and 25% for SC, ST and PwD, for both the fellowship and the teaching route. Above that, selection is by merit list, with cut-offs that move each cycle.

Is there a sectional cut-off for Parts A, B and C?

No. There is no separate cut-off for any part. Only the cumulative marks across all three parts are used to draw the merit list.

What is the age limit?

For the Junior Research Fellowship, not more than 30 years as on 1 December 2026 (the first day of the month in which the exam concludes), with up to five years' relaxation for OBC-NCL, SC, ST, PwD, PwBD and Third gender candidates and for women, and for research experience or ex-service. There is no upper age limit for Assistant Professor or for PhD admission.

I am in my final year of M.Sc. Can I apply?

Yes. Final-year and result-awaited candidates may apply provisionally. You must complete your Master's with the required percentage within two years of the result if you qualify for JRF or Assistant Professor, or within one year if you qualify for PhD admission only.

What is the new Life Sciences and Biotechnology paper?

From December 2026, the CSIR NET Life Sciences paper and the DBT Biotechnology Eligibility Test are merged into one paper, Life Sciences and Biotechnology (code 703). CSIR confirmed there is no reduction in fellowships, the paper will carry adequate optional questions from both domains, and qualified Biotechnology candidates are now eligible for all three result categories.

How many questions must I attempt?

It depends on your subject. Chemical, Earth and Life Sciences candidates attempt 75 questions in total; Mathematical Sciences, 60; Physical Sciences, 55. The part-wise limits are in Section 5, and answering more than the limit in any part means only the first answers up to the limit are evaluated.

What is the negative marking?

25% of the question's marks for a wrong answer in most parts. Earth Sciences Part C is stricter at 33%. Mathematical Sciences Part C has no negative marking, but its questions can have more than one correct option and give credit only for a complete, correct set.

How much is the JRF stipend?

Rs.37,000 per month for the first two years, plus an annual contingent grant of Rs.20,000 and house rent allowance where applicable. On upgrading to Senior Research Fellow, it becomes Rs.42,000 per month.

How long is the JRF certificate valid?

Two years from the effective date. You must accept a fellowship and join within that window. The Assistant Professor certificate has no end period.

Is the paper in Hindi?

The paper is bilingual, in Hindi and English. You choose your medium in the application form. If the two versions ever differ, the English version is treated as final.

Can I change my subject code after applying?

Do not count on it. The subject code fixes your paper, and changes are not a routine request. Choose carefully before you submit, using the syllabus on csirhrdg.res.in.

Can I challenge the answer key?

Yes. After the exam, NTA displays the provisional answer key and recorded responses, and you can challenge any question online for a non-refundable Rs.200 per question, within the window and through the prescribed link only.

Does qualifying guarantee a fellowship?

Qualifying for JRF makes you eligible for the fellowship. Actual acceptance depends on finding a placement in a university, IIT or recognised research institution within the certificate's validity, and on the fellowship slots available. The exam is the key; the institution is the door.

What if I do not qualify this time?

The exam is held twice a year, so the next cycle follows in June 2027. Keep your error log from this attempt, target the previous cycle's cut-off for your subject and category, and you start the next cycle already ahead.

18. Part A practice set: 20 questions with answers

Part A is common to every subject and is worth 30 marks, the most predictable marks in the paper. Work through this set under a 20-minute clock, then check the answers and the one-line reasoning. If you miss more than five, Part A is your fastest source of improvement.

1 Find the next term: 2, 6, 12, 20, 30, ?

2 If A : B = 3 : 4 and B : C = 8 : 9, find A : C.

3 A train 120 m long passes a pole in 6 seconds. Find its speed in km/h.

4 Find the simple interest on Rs.5,000 at 8% per annum for 3 years.

5 Which number does not belong: 8, 27, 64, 100, 125?

6 If CAT = 24 (sum of letter positions 3 + 1 + 20), what is DOG?

7 A person walks 5 km north, turns right and walks 3 km, then turns right and walks 5 km. How far and in which direction from the start?

8 A price rises by 25% and then falls by 20%. What is the net change?

9 Find the next term: 1, 4, 9, 16, ?

10 Two fair dice are thrown. What is the probability that the sum is 7?

11 A father is four times his son's age. After 20 years he will be twice his son's age. Find the son's present age.

12 The average of five numbers is 18. If the number 24 is removed, what is the new average?

13 A can finish a job in 12 days and B in 18 days. Working together, how long will they take?

14 Find the next term: 3, 6, 11, 18, 27, ?

15 All roses are flowers. Some flowers fade quickly. Do these statements prove that some roses fade quickly?

16 What is the angle between the hour and minute hands of a clock at 3:30?

17 Find the compound interest on Rs.1,000 at 10% per annum for 2 years.

18 A bar chart shows the values 40, 60, 80, 100 and 120. What is their average?

19 Which number does not belong: 3, 5, 7, 9, 11?

20 Which of these is NOT a primary source: a research journal article, a patent, a textbook, a doctoral thesis?

Answer key

Q	Answer	Why
1	42	Differences rise 4, 6, 8, 10; add 12.
2	2 : 3	A : B : C = 6 : 8 : 9, so A : C = 6 : 9.
3	72 km/h	120/6 = 20 m/s; 20 x 18/5 = 72 km/h.
4	Rs.1,200	5000 x 8 x 3 / 100.
5	100	8, 27, 64, 125 are cubes; 100 is not.
6	26	4 + 15 + 7 = 26.
7	3 km East	Two north and south legs cancel; net 3 km east.
8	No change (0%)	1.25 x 0.80 = 1.00.
9	25	Perfect squares: 1, 4, 9, 16, 25.
10	1/6	Six favourable outcomes (1-6 to 6-1) of 36.
11	10 years	4s + 20 = 2(s + 20), so s = 10.
12	16.5	(5 x 18 - 24)/4 = 66/4.
13	7.2 days	1/12 + 1/18 = 5/36, so 36/5 days.
14	38	Differences rise 3, 5, 7, 9; add 11.
15	No	Both statements are particular; no certain conclusion follows.
16	75 degrees	Hour hand 105 degrees, minute hand 180 degrees.
17	Rs.210	1000 x (1.10 squared - 1) = 210.
18	80	(40 + 60 + 80 + 100 + 120)/5.
19	9	9 is not prime.
20	A textbook	A textbook compiles secondary material; the others are primary.

What this set is really testing

Notice the mix: number series, ratio, time-speed-distance, percentages, probability, syllogism, clocks, data interpretation and research aptitude. Those are the recurring families in Part A. Drill each family separately until the pattern recognition is automatic, then practise them interleaved, exactly as they appear in the real paper.

19. Part A topic map: the seven families

Part A questions look random but they come from a small set of families. Learn the family and you learn the trick. Drill them one at a time until the pattern is automatic, then mix them.

Family	What it tests	How to drill it
1. Number series and patterns	Spotting the rule behind a sequence	20 sequences a day; write the rule in words before the next term

Family	What it tests	How to drill it
2. Ratio, percentage and proportion	Comparing quantities; net change	Practise 'rise then fall' and successive-percentage problems
3. Time, speed, distance and work	Rates and combined effort	Learn the unit-conversion table (m/s to km/h) by heart
4. Data interpretation	Reading charts, tables and graphs	One DI set daily; read the axes before the numbers
5. Logical reasoning and syllogism	Valid vs. plausible conclusions	Draw Venn diagrams for every syllogism, every time
6. Puzzles and arrangement	Ordering and constraints	Start from the most fixed clue; keep a grid
7. Research aptitude	Scientific method and reasoning	Know primary vs. secondary sources; hypothesis, variable, control

Why Part A deserves its own section

Part A is 30 marks out of 200 — 15% of the paper — and it is the same for every candidate regardless of subject. It is the only part where a week of focused practice reliably moves your score, because the question types repeat. Science candidates often neglect it because it is 'not their subject'. That neglect is exactly why Part A is the cheapest place to gain a rank.

> **The 20-minute habit**
>
> Spend 20 minutes on Part A every single day of your preparation. Over eight weeks that is nearly 19 hours of aptitude practice — more than enough to make Part A a near-automatic 24 to 30 marks on exam day.

20. The late-start plan: 30 days from 20 November

If you are reading this in late November, do not follow the 60-day plan and panic. Follow this instead. It trades breadth for targeting, and it is built on the fact that CSIR NET rewards precision more than coverage.

Week	Dates (example)	Focus	Rule for the week
1. Triage	20 – 26 Nov	Sit one diagnostic mock; list your ten weakest topics; do not study anything else yet	Find the leaks before you pour in water
2. Attack	27 Nov – 3 Dec	Fix the ten weak topics only; 20 minutes of Part A daily	Ten fixed topics beat a hundred skimmed ones
3. Sharpen	4 – 10 Dec	Two full mocks in exam conditions; Part C practice; build one-page concept sheets	Analyse each mock for three hours
4. Taper	11 – 18 Dec	One mock early; then revise only your error log and concept sheets; sleep on a schedule	Stop new material five days out

The three decisions that matter most when you are short on time

1. **Protect Part A.** Twenty minutes a day, no exceptions. It is the most reliable return in the whole paper.

2 **Fix your ten weakest topics, not your favourite ones.** Study what you avoid, because that is where your marks are hiding.

3 **Practise the clock, not just the content.** Two or three full mocks, properly analysed, are worth more than a week of extra reading.

> **Do not skip the attempt limits**
>
> When time is short, the temptation is to answer everything and hope. Resist it. The attempt limits and the negative-marking maths are enforced regardless of how you prepared, so the strategy in Section 12 matters even more under time pressure.

21. The mock analysis template and ten high-yield habits

Copy this table into a notebook and fill one row after every mock. The act of writing it down is what turns a mock into an improvement.

Field	Mock 1	Mock 2	Mock 3	Mock 4	Mock 5
Total score (/200)					
Part A score (/30)					
Part B score					
Part C score					
Part A time used					
Part C time used					
Attempts vs. limits (any breach?)					
Part C accuracy (%)					
Top three error causes					

Ten high-yield habits

1 Twenty minutes of Part A practice every single day.

2 One full-length mock a week, always at your real shift time.

3 Three hours of analysis for every hour of mock.

4 A single running error log, with the fix dated.

5 One-page concept or formula sheets per unit, built as you revise.

6 Never cross an attempt limit — count as you go.

7 Leave a question blank rather than guess blindly.

8 In Mathematics Part C, attempt only what you can solve cleanly.

9 Revise only your own sheets and error log in the final week.

10 A fixed sleep schedule from the start of the last week.

22. The five subjects: how to attack Part C

Part C is where the rank is decided, and its character differs by subject. Here is what to watch for in yours.

Chemical Sciences (701)

Part C carries 25 questions at 4 marks each, with a 1-mark penalty for a wrong answer. The questions are typically multi-step: a reaction scheme, a spectroscopic deduction, or a numerical. Budget roughly four minutes per question and skip anything that turns into a long chain of calculation you cannot finish.

Physical Sciences (705)

Part C is the smallest in question count — 30 questions, attempt 20 — but the richest per question at 5 marks, with a 1.25-mark penalty. Questions lean on applying concepts and setting up a solution rather than recalling a result. Experimental design and electronics are the areas candidates most often under-prepare; give them deliberate time.

Life Sciences and Biotechnology (703)

This is the first cycle of the merged paper. Use the optional-question design to your advantage: if you come from a traditional Life Sciences background, seek out the life-sciences questions; if you come from Biotechnology, seek out the biotech ones. Do not spend time on the domain you were not trained in when questions from your own domain are available. Part C carries a 1-mark penalty for a wrong answer.

Mathematical Sciences (704)

Part C is the odd one out. There is no negative marking, but each question can have more than one correct option and credit is given only for a complete, correct set — a near-miss scores the same as a blank. That makes it a precision game: attempt only the questions you can reason to a clean, defensible answer set, and never guess a partial set.

Earth, Atmospheric, Ocean and Planetary Sciences (702)

Part C here is the riskiest in the entire exam: the penalty for a wrong answer is 33%, not 25%. With 25 questions at 4 marks each, a careless guess costs more than in any other subject. Attempt Part C here with the most discipline of all: answer what you know, and leave the rest blank.

> **One rule that applies to all five**
>
> Attempt limits are enforced. Decide your Part C count before the clock starts, keep a tally as you answer, and never let a later high-value question go unread because you over-answered an earlier part.

23. Glossary

The words that appear in the bulletin, in plain English.

Term	What it means
CSIR NET	The Joint CSIR-UGC National Eligibility Test, conducted twice a year by NTA for CSIR.
NTA	National Testing Agency, the body that conducts the exam and hosts the application portal.
JRF	Junior Research Fellowship — a funded research position with a monthly stipend.
SRF	Senior Research Fellow — the upgraded fellowship after two years, at a higher stipend.
Assistant Professor	The teaching post you become eligible for by qualifying the test; also called Lectureship.
Category 1 / 2 / 3	The three result outcomes: JRF plus teaching, teaching plus PhD admission, and PhD admission only.
Part A / B / C	The three sections of the paper: common aptitude, subject basics, and subject analytical questions.
Attempt limit	The maximum number of questions you may answer in a part; extra answers are ignored.
Negative marking	The marks deducted for a wrong answer — usually 25% of the question's value.
Benchmark	The minimum aggregate percentage you must cross (33%, or 25% for reserved categories).
Merit list	The ranked list of successful candidates, drawn from cumulative marks across all parts.
Percentile score	Your position relative to other candidates in the same subject, shown with your marks.
Contingent grant	An annual research-expense grant paid to the fellow, separate from the stipend.
DBT-BET	The Biotechnology Eligibility Test, merged into the Life Sciences paper from December 2026.
LS-BT	Life Sciences and Biotechnology — the new merged subject, code 703.

24. Exam craft: the small skills that quietly cost marks

Two candidates can know the same science and score fifteen marks apart on craft alone. These are the habits that decide the margin.

Read the stem twice, and look for the negation

Multiple-choice questions often hide the answer in one word. 'Which of the following is NOT correct', 'all of the following EXCEPT', 'which statement is false' — the science is identical, but the answer flips. Circle the negating word the moment you see it, before you read the options. This one habit saves more marks than any formula.

Watch the units and the order of magnitude

A large share of wrong answers in numerical questions are not wrong reasoning — they are unit errors or a slipped power of ten. Write the unit beside every number as you work, and sanity-check the size of your answer: if a molecular mass comes out in kilograms, something has gone wrong.

Use the two-pass method in Part B

First pass: answer only the questions you recognise instantly, and move on the moment you hesitate. Second pass: return to the ones you flagged, with the clock in view. This keeps easy marks from being swallowed by one stubborn question, and it keeps your pace honest.

Make the on-screen calculator work for you

The test is computer-based, and the calculator is on the screen. Before exam day, practise with a screen calculator so the mouse work is automatic. Never let a calculator step eat thirty seconds of a two-minute question — if the arithmetic is long, the question was probably designed to be reasoned, not computed.

Do not let question one set your mood

A hard opening question is common and deliberate. If the first question resists, flag it and move on; your confidence returns the moment you bank two easy ones. Candidates who stall on the first question often lose five minutes and their composure at the same time.

The blank is a tool

On this paper, a blank answer costs nothing and a wrong answer costs marks. Use the blank deliberately: leave anything you cannot reason to a confident answer, and spend the saved time on questions you can. Disciplined blanking is not giving up — it is arithmetic.

25. Quick-reference card

Screenshot this page. It is the whole playbook in one view.

Deadlines

Application + fee: 5 November 2026. Late fee: 6 – 9 November. Correction: 10 – 12 November. Exam: 19, 22, 27 December 2026.

Subject	Code	Attempt A / B / C	Total attempts	Part C penalty
Chemical Sciences	701	15 / 35 / 25	75	25%
Earth Sciences	702	15 / 35 / 25	75	33%
Life Sciences & Biotechnology	703	15 / 35 / 25	75	25%
Mathematical Sciences	704	15 / 25 / 20	60	None (all-or-nothing)
Physical Sciences	705	15 / 20 / 20	55	25%

The numbers to remember	Value
Total marks / duration	200 marks / 180 minutes
Minimum benchmark	33% (General, EWS, OBC); 25% (SC, ST, PwD)
JRF age limit	30 years as on 1 December 2026
JRF stipend	Rs.37,000 per month, rising to Rs.42,000 as SRF
Application fee	Rs.1,150 / Rs.600 / Rs.325 by category
Answer-key challenge	Rs.200 per question
JRF certificate validity	Two years

Final checklist before exam day

- Application submitted and fee paid; confirmation page saved.
- Subject code confirmed against the syllabus.
- Attempt limits and clock plan written down and memorised.
- At least five full-length mocks sat and analysed.
- Error log and one-page concept sheets complete.
- Admit card, ID and centre route confirmed.
- Sleep schedule fixed for the final week.

Sources

This playbook was compiled in October 2026 from official and primary sources: the National Testing Agency public notice inviting online applications for Joint CSIR-UGC NET December 2026 (dated 7 October 2026); the Joint CSIR-UGC NET December 2026 Information Bulletin, including the scheme of examination and the revised Life Sciences and Biotechnology syllabus; the CSIR-HRDG notice dated 13 January 2026 on the introduction of the Joint CSIR-UGC-DBT JRF-NET examination; the CSIR-HRDG June 2026 cut-off notification and result; and the CSIR-HRDG JRF guidelines covering stipend and tenure. Where a figure is quoted, it is drawn from these documents. Official notices may be revised — always confirm final details at csirnet.nta.nic.in and csirhrdg.res.in.

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